4NG Fanatics

Boy in Hoodie

By Daniel MacIvor

INTRODUCTION

This is the story of the "Dead Cat Kid," as he's known by his classmates. He's fascinated by death — curious about it in a philosophical sense — but he's not morbid, and he DID NOT kill a cat.

But which is more important, the truth or perception? Boy in Hoodie by Daniel MacIvor

Outside. Night. A neighborhood. A teenaged boy in a hoodie holds a flashlight to his face.

BOY: **(Pg 25-40)** Death. Death. Death. Death. Comes. Not. Death comes not because death is already here. Death lives. Life is Death. *(He drops the flashlight to his side)* "Life Is Death". As a band. Excellent band name.

I'm standing in Beverly Fitzgerald's driveway. It's Saturday night and I'm standing in Beverly Fitzgerald's driveway looking at the moon. *(He looks up)*

I'm supposed to be good at math because I got a telescope for my birthday. Because that's what I asked for. It's a good one. I could have got a laptop. But I asked for a telescope instead. And now everyone thinks I'm good at math. And because now people who are bad at math are really supposed to be good at math, but just getting taught math wrong, I have to go to a special class. Maybe I'm bad at math because I don't like math. Maybe I just wanted a telescope and it has nothing to do with math. Just because a person asks for a telescope doesn't mean they're good at math, maybe they're just depressed. *(He looks up)*

I remember when my father died. *(He looks to us)* "*I have some bad news.*" My mother said that. "*I have some bad news.*" That's the first time anybody ever said that to me. . . . Ed has a rainbow on a t-shirt. A rainbow in his brain. You know, dream catchers and pot and a ponytail, a rainbow in his brain. My Mom's been trying to get him to cut his ponytail for years. It's not even a ponytail now. It's more like a skinny grey tail now. It's

okay to me but kind of depressing. Getting old. Shrinking. Turning to dust. He never asked me to call him Dad. I appreciated that. My mom was always "*you can call him Dad if you want to*." And this is way after the best-before date for that conversation. Ed doesn't care. We don't need to have that conversation. Ed and me have lots of *conversations*. Conversation. That's what we call it. Ed says "Perhaps we need to have a Conversation". Ed's hilarious. *(laughs -- He looks up)*

And I'm standing in Beverly Fitzgerald's driveway and I'm laughing because I'm thinking about something Ed said while we were having a Conversation and I hear: *"What's so funny?"* And that's one of those really hard questions to answer. Like "what are you thinking". Actually it's even harder to answer than "what are you thinking" because whatever you're thinking had better be funny or you'll look like a knob. And it's especially hard because you didn't know anyone could hear you, and that is more especially hard because as soon as you realize someone could hear you, you immediately forget what you laughed at, and most especially it's a hard question because Beverly Fitzgerald is asking it. And this is when I realize that Beverly Fitzgerald is sitting in the dark on her front step. How long has she been there?

And I say: *Oh hey.* And she says again: *What's so funny?* And I say: *Just life, you know, the joke of life you know. We are puppets, we are sheep, as The Down say.* And she says: *I love The Down.*

Beverly Fitzgerald loves The Down? Beverly Fitzgerald is a cheerleader. Beverly Fitzgerald is a cheerleader who goes to church. The Down is the music you put on when you want your used-to-be best friend from grade seven who is now really boring to go home. The Down is the only music my Mom yells "*turn that down"* at. Even Ed. At first he was all "*whatever*" but one time he came into my room and he says "*How can that music be in any way <u>helpful</u>?*" Helpful? I'm not looking for *help.* If I was looking for help I'd call the Youth Distress Line. I'm not looking for help -- I'm looking for confirmation.

Beverly Fitzgerald loves The Down. Beverly Fitzgerald goes out with college guys. Beverly Fitzgerald is popular. Nobody popular likes The Down. *(a moment)*

When I was popular I didn't know what popular was . . . I had a website. It was pictures of cats. Not cute cats or stupid dressed up cats or anything. One time there was this site of cats with stuff on them? Just random stuff. It was hilarious. So I started taking pictures of my cat with like a book on him or a slipper or a mug. The mug was hilarious. They're pretty good. And one time a picture of a dead cat.

It was just some random dead cat. He was hit by a car. It was just a picture. It was a huge deal. It was on the news. I had to change schools. Why is that better? At least at my old school people knew me. First day at the new school I'm the Dead Cat Kid that nobody knows. Good luck with that. I was cut off. Cut off. That was cold. *(He looks up for a moment)*

So, I go to this new school. At first it's like I'm wearing a stay-back-500-feet shirt. At first people are just scared. Then people get curious. The really creepy people start coming around. But they have true-creepiness radar and they can tell when somebody is a cat killer or somebody just took a picture of an already dead cat. So, they just crawl back under the bleachers. Then the more-normal people. They can be good at it. They start out with talking about music or having a laugh. But they really just want answers to questions. To report back to the group. They want the story. The Story of the Dead Cat Kid. *(laughs)* That's the album. Drops this Christmas. Walmarts worldwide. *(laughs)* And I'm the Dead Cat Kid and I don't know anyone and I'm standing in Beverly Fitzgerald's driveway and I just found out she loves The Down and her parents are away. She invites me inside. *(He looks up for a moment)* And I didn't say "yes" or anything. I just went in. Beverly Fitzgerald gets me a beer from her fridge. I just put it on the counter because I don't drink. Beverly Fitzgerald's drinking vodka. And I ask her if she wants to *have a conversation* and she doesn't know what that means. So, I explain it to her and she really gets excited. So, we *have a conversation* but I can tell why she doesn't call it *having*

a conversation because it makes her get really, really quiet. First she mostly just looked at her hands and then stared at me. Finally she started talking but it wasn't a conversation it was just her telling a long story about some party she didn't go to tonight and then she got quiet again. And I'm in Beverly Fitzgerald's [house] and her parents are away and she's maybe more than a little bit drunk and we just had a conversation. And I feel like this: *Phew.* Phew. That's the perfect word for the sound because the sound is the word and the feeling all together: *Phew. Everything's going to be okay. Things are going to get normal finally. Things are going to get better than normal.* (*He holds the flashlight to his face. A moment)*

Beverly Fitzgerald threw up. She stayed in the bathroom for a long time. When she came out she had another vodka. She talked about the party again and answered the phone a bunch of times. It seemed like time to leave a couple of times so I got up to go and she walked me to the door. And we were at the door and I turned to her cause I'm not sure to kiss her or hug her to shake hands and she says "*Did you kill the cat?*" *(He turns on the flashlight)*

I was just coming round the corner. And I had the flashlight on. On my feet on the sidewalk. Sometimes taking pictures of my feet on the sidewalk. And I stop and I see this thing on the road. And it's a cat and it's dead. It must have been hit by a car but there's no blood and nothing flattened. It's just like a normal looking cat lying down on the road, but he's dead. And you can tell he's dead. And the only way to tell that he's dead is not by something that's there–guts or crushed bones–but by what's not there. Do cats think?

I moved him to the sidewalk after. That's when I touched him. That's all. I didn't kill him. It was just a picture. *(He turns off the flashlight)*

And Beverly Fitzgerald says "*Did you kill the cat?*" And I say yes. *(He looks up)*

Ed says "*People see what they see -- you can only be responsible for what you do*." But I say, you can be responsible for what they see. It'll probably be easier in the end. *(He looks at us)*

Ed liked the picture. Not like he *liked* it but he got it. Yeah yeah, get me the Youth Distress Line please it's an emergency. It's all good. I can talk to Ed. We'll have a Conversation about it. My Mom would freak. She hated that picture. She hated it more than anybody. It's just a picture. Pixilations of pixilations. There's nothing there. *(He looks at us)*

And right now Beverly Fitzgerald is on the phone or at a party and she's telling everyone she talks to and everyone who wants to talk to her what the Dead Cat Kid said.

Monday will be interesting. Could work. For a band. *(He holds the flashlight in his face and speaks in a scary voice)* Ladies and Gentlemen, put your hands together for "Monday Will Be Interesting"!

SOURCE INFORMATION

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